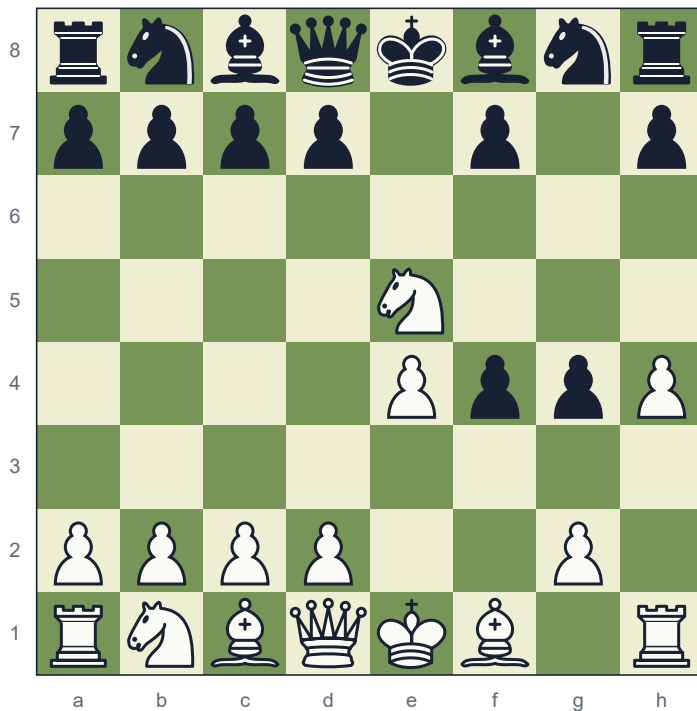


Compensation is a balance sheet



KG-01 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

The f-pawn buys a chance at central control and development, while weakening the king. Compensation must exist in the current position; the word gambit does not preserve it indefinitely.

HOW TO DECIDE

Count material, useful developed pieces, safe king squares and concrete threats. Ask what happens if Black returns the pawn or exchanges queens. If your compensation disappears, change the plan instead of sacrificing again.

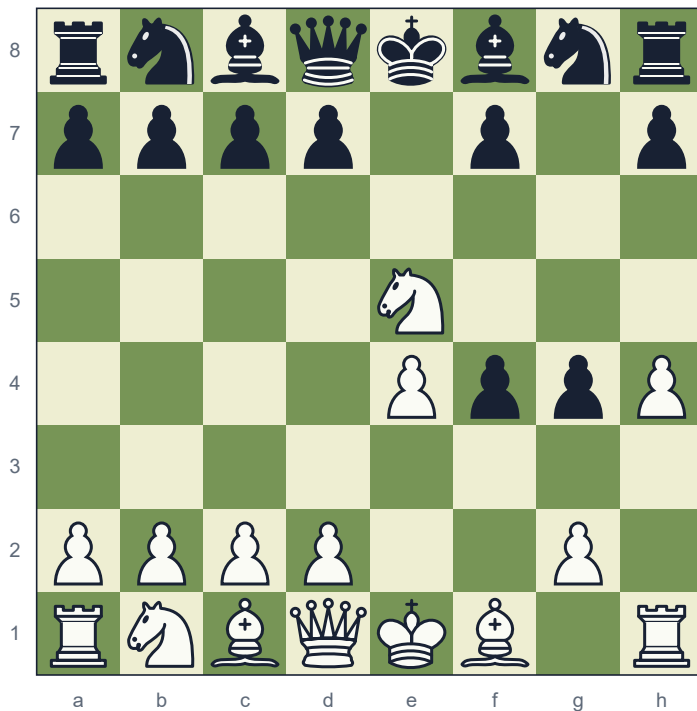
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can neutralize activity with ...d5 and timely exchanges rather than trying to hold f4 forever.

BOARD DRILL

Play the endpoint twice: first pursue development, then try to recover f4 immediately. Compare the time cost and resulting king safety.

The h4 lever and the g-pawn chain



KG-01 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A supported pawn on f4 is hard to win directly. h4 challenges the g5 support and can force Black to choose between advancing, exchanging and reinforcing.

HOW TO DECIDE

After ...g4, name the attacked knight and its legal safe squares. Before hxg5, calculate the recapture and which rook gains the h-file. Keep track of the h-pawn's new file after captures.

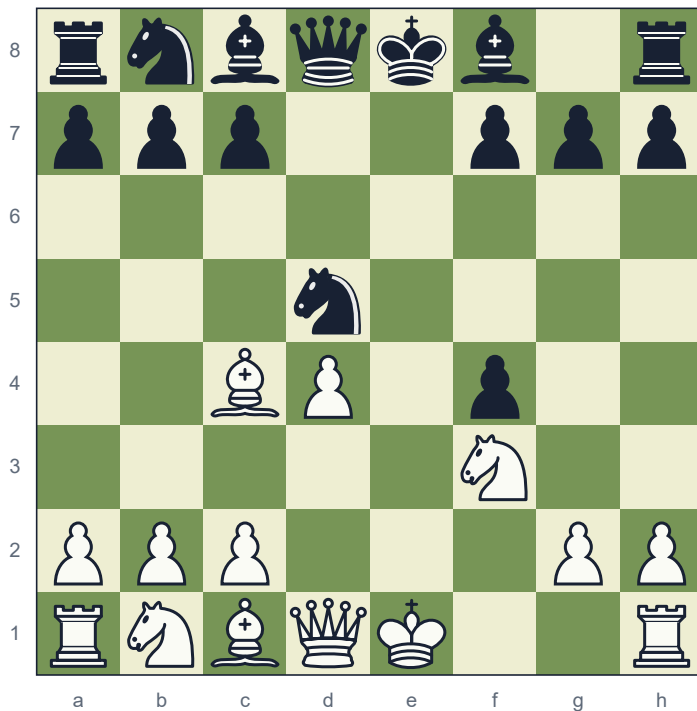
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

...d6 denies e5, while ...h6 changes the capture sequence. The same h4 move can lead to very different knight routes.

BOARD DRILL

Set up the position before h4 and compare ...g4, ...h6 and ...Bg7 on a board. Explain one concrete difference for each reply.

The f-file is not open until it is open



KG-09 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

After f2-f4 and ...exf4, the f-file still contains Black's pawn on f4. A rook on f1 cannot attack through it. Recovery or displacement of that pawn changes the file.

HOW TO DECIDE

Trace every square from the rook to f7. Identify blockers and defenders. Choose development that prepares a real file opening instead of calling a blocked file an attack.

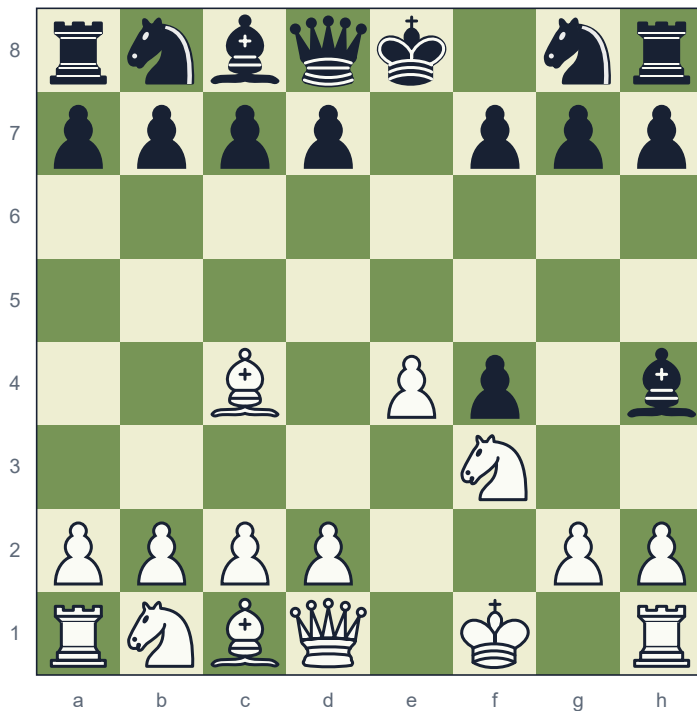
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may return f4 to close another line or exchange attacking pieces. An open file with no entry square is not enough.

BOARD DRILL

Point to the first occupied square on the f-file in three different accepted-gambit diagrams, then explain how it might be removed.

When the king cannot castle



KG-13 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

Kf1 is a legal defensive response in some lines, but it permanently changes rook coordination. A central king can survive behind a stable center and become vulnerable when files open.

HOW TO DECIDE

Find the next central pawn break for both sides. Develop with that deadline in mind and look for a safe king route only after answering concrete checks. Do not spend several king moves without a reason.

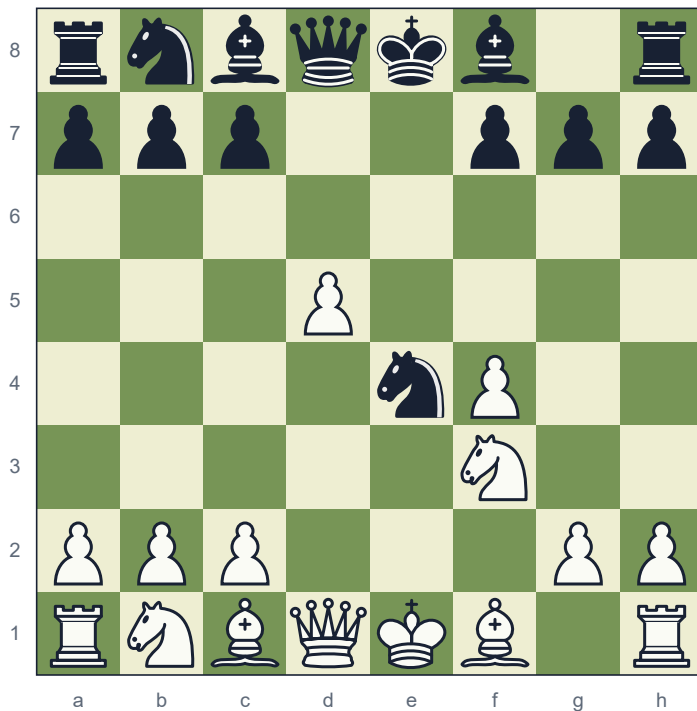
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can use ...d5 to open the game while the h1 rook is disconnected. A queen trade may help White more than a speculative attack.

BOARD DRILL

Play a Kf1 endpoint with the aim of connecting the rooks safely. Record how many tempi that task takes.

Central countergambits



KG-19 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

The Falkbeer attacks the center rather than defending e5. The advanced e4 pawn can restrict White and gain time against developing pieces.

HOW TO DECIDE

Challenge the wedge with d3 when appropriate. Calculate exchanges all the way to the recapture, then assess the resulting knight activity and king safety.

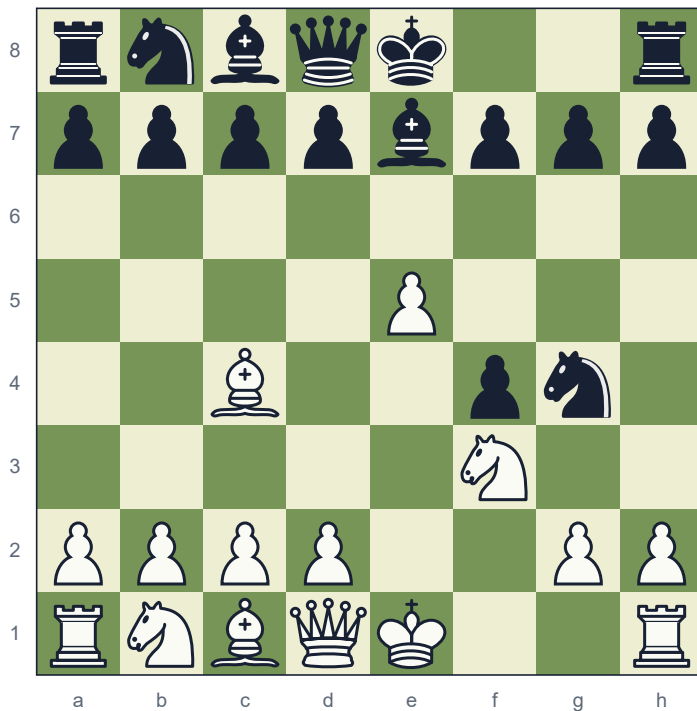
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can return material to develop rapidly. Holding an extra pawn while leaving the king on an open file can reverse the evaluation.

BOARD DRILL

Compare the ...e4 and ...exf4 versions after ...d5. State which one transposes to the Modern Defense and which creates a distinct center.

Attacking f7 without wishful thinking



KG-14 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

f7 is initially defended only by the king, but that fact alone does not justify a sacrifice. The king may capture a bishop and escape if White has insufficient follow-up.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate $Bxf7+$ through the best king reply and the next forcing move. Count supporting attackers and safe flight squares. Compare a quiet developing move before sacrificing.

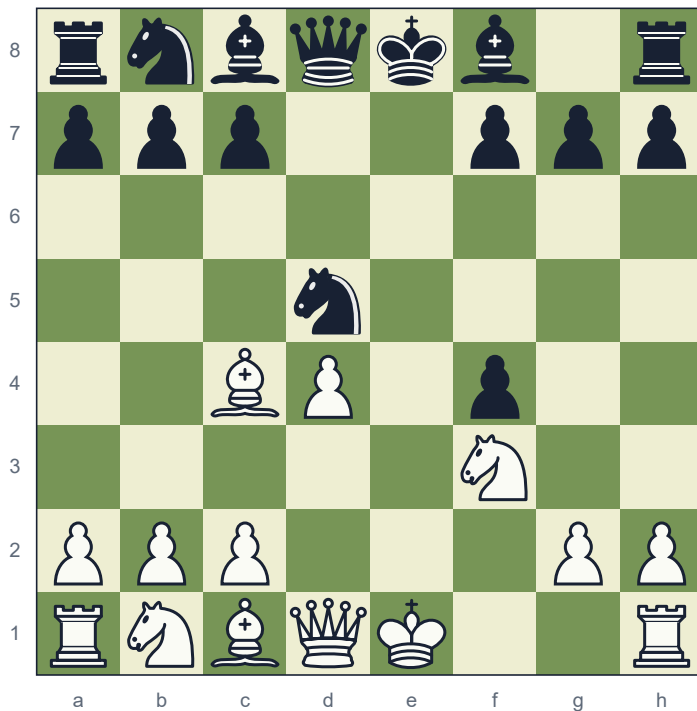
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may answer an attack with $\dots d5$, interposing a pawn and opening the center. Defenders can arrive with tempo.

BOARD DRILL

In one laboratory, list all legal checks but choose the best move only after calculating the opponent's reply.

Trading queens when a pawn down



KG-09 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A pawn-down endgame can be playable if your pieces are active and the opponent has weaknesses. It can also remove the compensation you relied on.

HOW TO DECIDE

Before a queen trade, compare pawn count, king activity and whether a target can be attacked. Do not refuse every trade merely because you started a gambit.

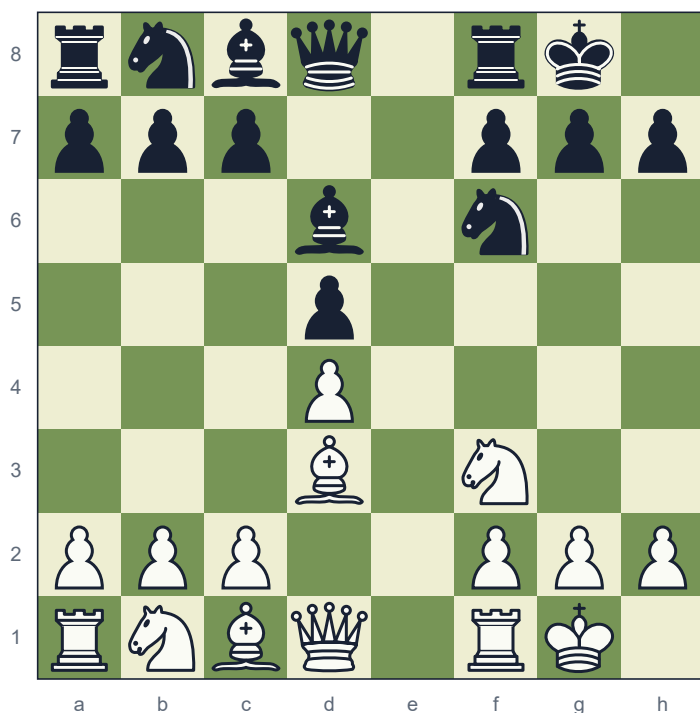
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may force simplification when your attack has stalled. Maintaining queens at the cost of another pawn can make the defense harder.

BOARD DRILL

At an endpoint, remove neither queen by hand. Find a legal queen-trade route and compare the resulting pawn weaknesses.

The boundary of a King's Gambit repertoire



KG-28 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

The opening requires 1.e4 e5. French, Caro-Kann, Sicilian and Scandinavian replies need real companion choices; 2.f4 against them is a different opening.

HOW TO DECIDE

Use the bridge lines to reach familiar development, then deepen the defenses you meet most often. Against Sicilian 2...Nc6 or 2...e6, a simple 3.d3 followed by g3 and Bg2 is a bridge, not the 3.Bb5+ line shown against ...d6.

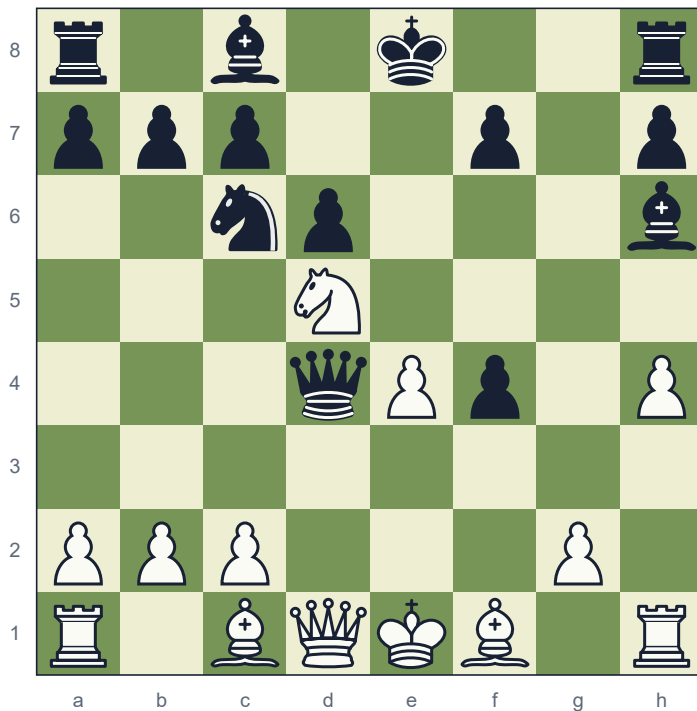
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can prevent your favorite opening on move one. Trying to force its name usually creates an unrelated and poorly prepared position.

BOARD DRILL

Sort ten imagined first replies into: King's Gambit available, bridge covered, or separate study needed. Include ...Nf6, ...b6 and ...Nc6 as separate-study examples.

Loose pieces and forks



KG-03 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

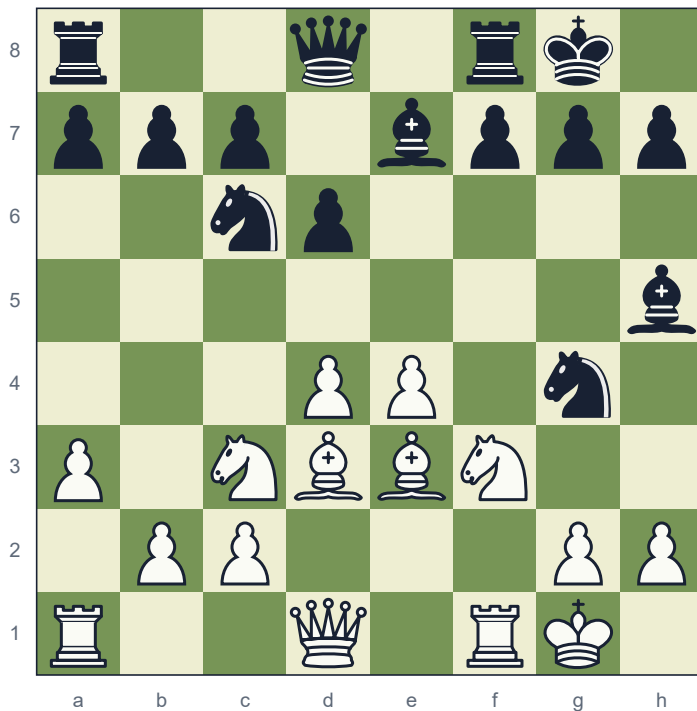
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

A similar position with an extra black developing move can change the tactics. Do not treat Nxg4 as universal whenever ...d6 attacks Ne5.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Pins and discovered attacks



KG-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can challenge the center with ...d5 or ...c5. An undefended e4 pawn can become the target of ...Nxe4 tactics.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



KG-13 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

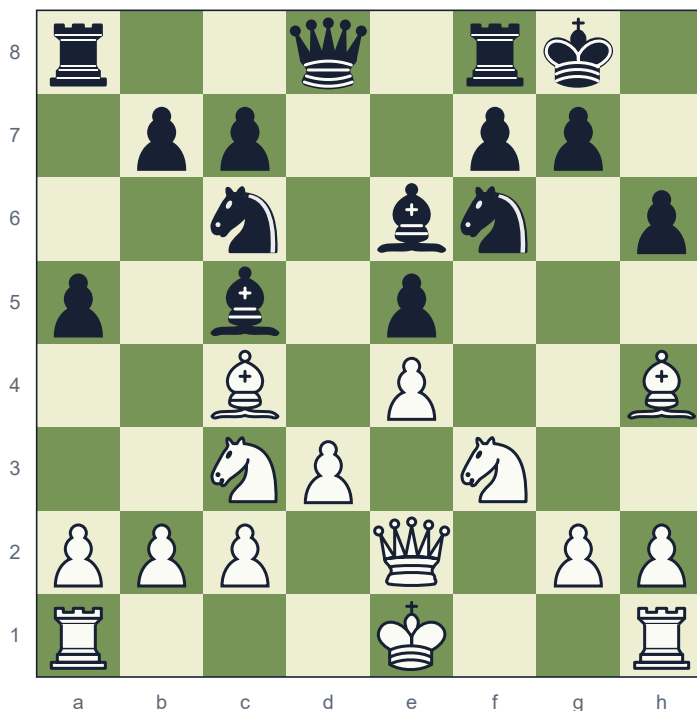
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can open the center with ...d5. Do not continue a routine castling plan after the king has moved.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



KG-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

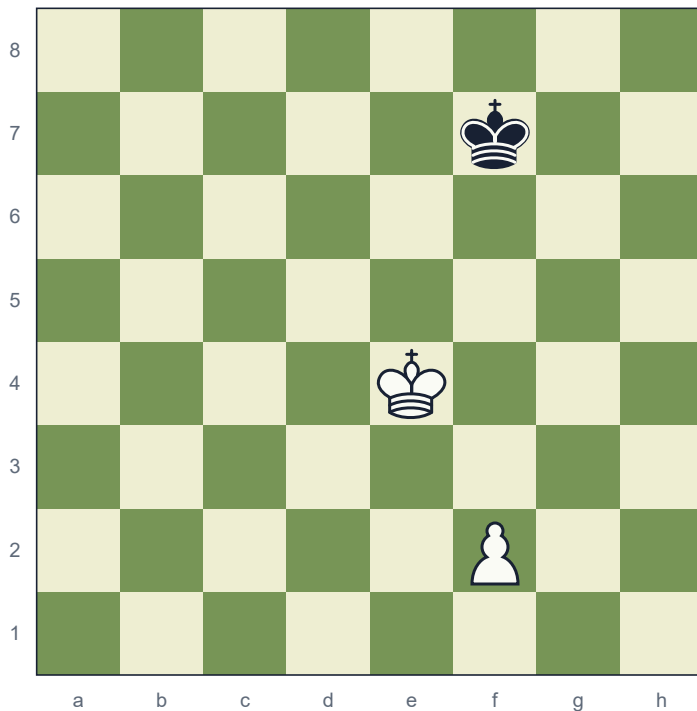
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can use ...Bg4 to pin Nf3 or open the center. Do not weaken the king with repeated pawn moves while pieces remain at home.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

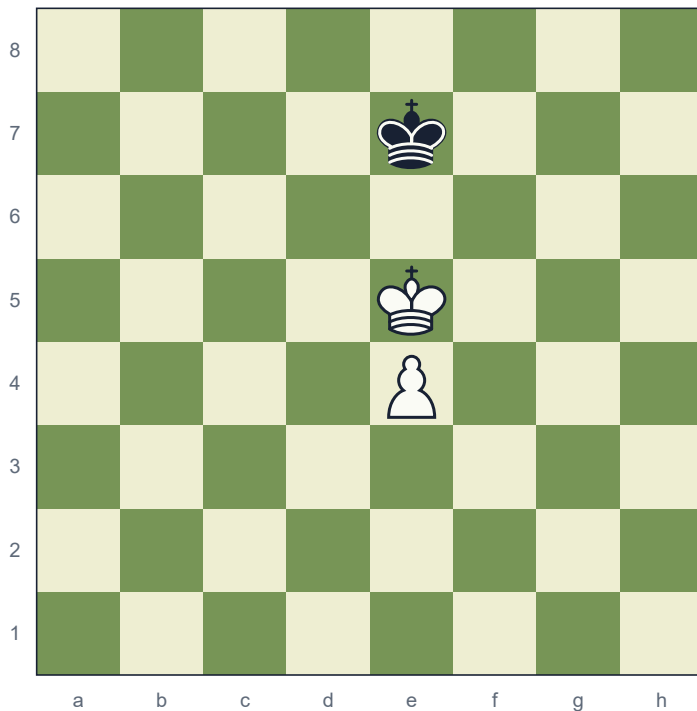
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

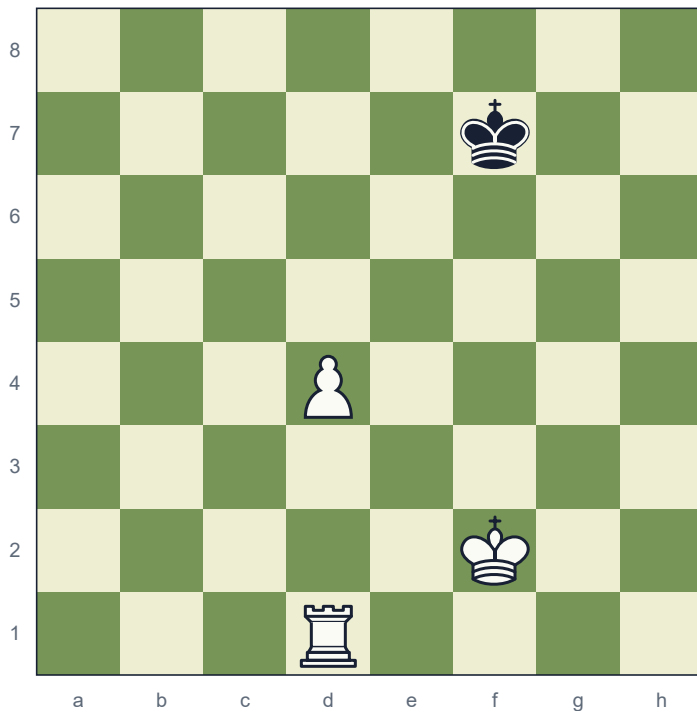
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

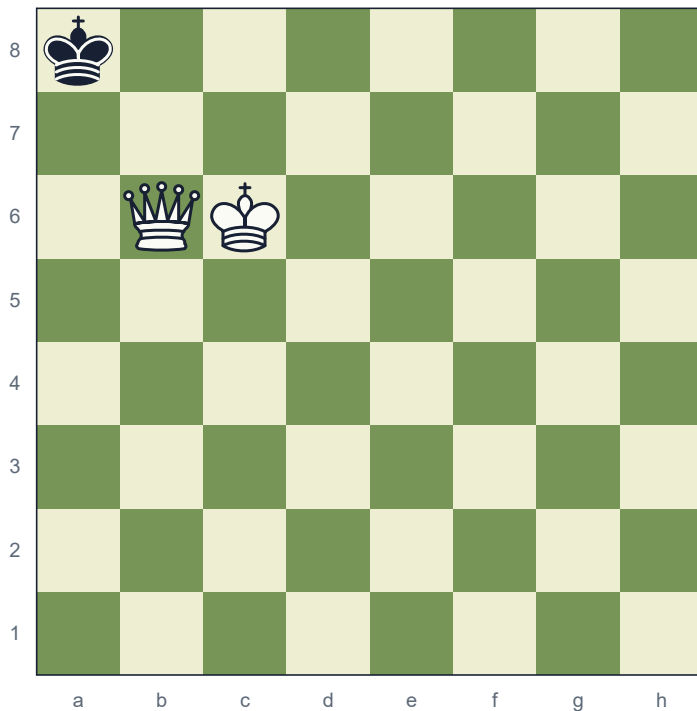
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

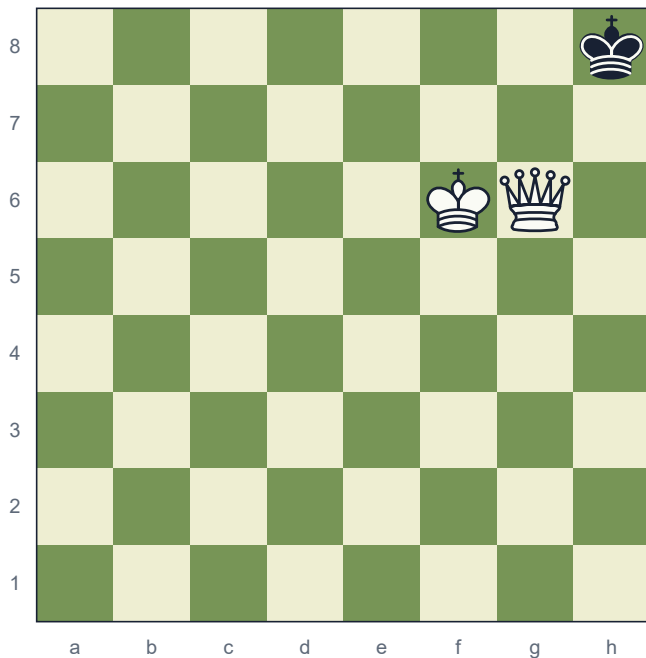
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

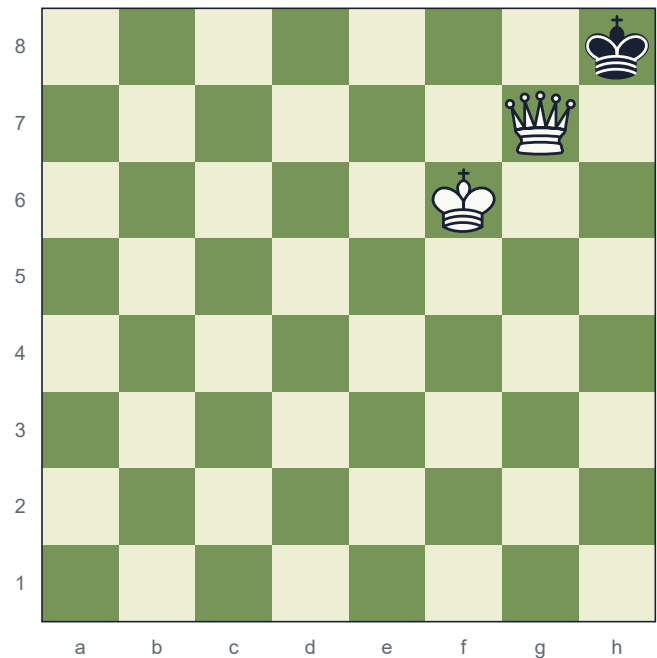
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

The opening requires 1.e4 e5. French, Caro-Kann, Sicilian and Scandinavian replies need real companion choices; 2.f4 against them is a different opening.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.